in Chunchura by the TMC's Asit Mazumdar. In fact, her growing unpopularity in Hooghly had left the BJP leadership wondering if she should be replaced by a new candidate. Even the TMC's surveys showed Locket's approval rating among her electorate to be one of the lowest among all the 42 MPs. "Rachana's show has made her a household name. Women connect with her promptly. Since Locket is already on the back foot, we believe we can woo voters through Rachana," a TMC source says.

Rachana herself has faced a few embarrassments, though. During campaigning, when asked about the alleged lack of industrialisation in Bengal, Rachana, referring to the smoke from factory chimneys she had seen on the way—and trying to make the point that Bengal has enough industry—enunciated thus with a wave of her hands: "*Dhoan…dhoan*" (smoke…smoke). It instantly provoked memes poking fun at her. Significantly, Singur, the seat of Mamata's anti-Tata movement that handed her Bengal's reins, falls under Hooghly.

In Ghatal, Hiran is linking every allegation of corruption and administrative mishandling directly to Dev, who has made the materialisation of the Ghatal Master Plan—a mega flood management programme—his poll plank. In the recent past, one of Dev's confidants was accused of taking a bribe against the promise of a government job. The fact that Dev was grilled by the Enforcement Directorate twice in connection with the cattle smuggling case has helped the BJP target him effectively. Abhishek has claimed that Hiran—who won on a BJP ticket from the Kharagpur Sadar assembly in 2021—had met him, hoping to rejoin the party. Hiran has rubbished the allegation.

The run up to the polls in Hooghly and Ghatal has grabbed eyeballs for its spectacle of stars crossing swords. That interest should extend up to June 4, when they will get to know which actor becomes Politician No. 1 in their seat. ■



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MANDATE 2024 | AAP |

AAP'S SORDID S

By Avishek G. Dastidar

A week is a long time in politics, especially in election season. On May 10, the BJP was in shock after the Supreme Court granted interim bail to Aam Aadmi Party national convenor and Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal in the excise policy case (the BJP top leadership even called the SC order "extraordinary"). Kejriwal re-entered the poll campaign with a bang, making explosive allegations about the shifting power structure in the BJP top leadership.

A week later, though, the tables had been turned. At the centre of it was the party's Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal, 39, who alleged that she was beaten up at Kejriwal's official residence by his long-time private assistant Bibhav Kumar on May 13. Soon, AAP was forced into fire-fighting mode, and the BJP was back in the game, launching back-to-back rallies by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, party chief J.P. Nadda and Amit Shah.

With many of its 20 LS candidates (in Delhi, Punjab and Haryana) up in the last two legs of the polls, the controversy has disrupted their campaign momentum. Unwilling to cede an inch, AAP alleged a political conspiracy, even as Kejriwal dared the BJP to arrest all his leaders in one go after Bibhav was taken into police custody on May 18. "They arrested my PA… I say, why arrest our leaders one by one? Take all of us in one go," he said.

The Congress, AAP's ally in Delhi, has taken a cautious stand on the whole sordid saga. When questioned, party general secretary Priyanka Gandhi said she would stand by any woman who was a victim of an atrocity. In the INDIA bloc, the Congress is the only party with a direct seat-sharing agreement with AAP. Yet, so far it has maintained a careful distance from Kejriwal, not even addressing a joint press conference with him. Party sources say they will maintain silence till May 25 when Delhi and Haryana—